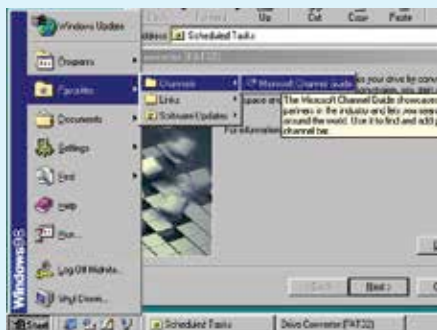


Windows 95 benefitted a lot from Windows 3.1's commercial success. For example, there was an extensive marketing campaign before launching Windows 95. It also was the first Microsoft OS to come with a Start button – which was advertised considerably by using the song *Start me up* by the Rolling Stones. Reportedly, Microsoft spent \$300 million in advertising for Windows 95 (a very big sum back then). This is why I give it an “average” rating – Microsoft ensured it would succeed in terms of sales figures with advertising, pre-bundling it with new systems, etc. I still think it was the next OS that would be the real success for us consumers.



Windows 98 – the global success

Windows 98 / 98 SE

Rating: Global success

The enhancements from Windows 95 were mind-boggling. The ability to theme, one-click-launch, active desktop, enhanced USB support, thumbnails, and a huge improvement in hardware support (drivers). Windows 98 SE also brought with it IE 5.0, ICS, and DirectX 6.1. Gaming on PCs took off, as did multimedia viewing. Bill Gates stood up in front of the press, trying to show off the Plug and Play features of Windows 98. An engineer then plugged in something, and bam! Blue Screen Of Death (BSOD)! Despite that Windows 98 went on to be all pervasive. Now that's a successful OS!

Windows ME

Rating: Poor

Yes Windows 2000 was released a few months before ME (Millennium Edition – also affectionately referred to by some users as “Mistake Edition”), but that was targeted at businesses. Windows



Windows ME – Mistake Edition?

ME was the consumer version, and it was a bomb. It did bring personalised menus and faster boot times than 98, and introduced us to Windows Movie Maker, but it was a buggy OS and almost seemed to be a rushed effort. Given that people were really happy with Windows 98, there seemed to be absolutely no reason to upgrade to ME. In fact, I personally know of quite a few people who bought new PCs in 2000, got ME preinstalled on them, and then promptly downgraded to Windows 98 SE (pirated).

Windows XP



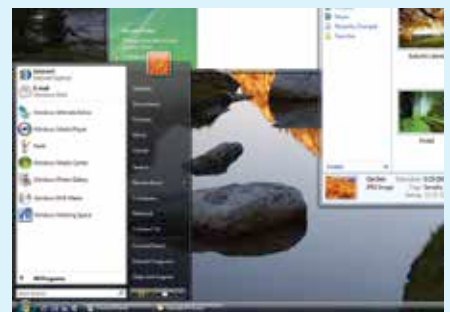
Windows XP – our favourite

Rating: Crazy success

If ever there was a success story of OSes, this would be it. The name was short for eXperience, and boy what an experience it was. While all other OSes before it added functionality, XP was the coming of age of the Windows GUI. Not only was it functional and really easy to use, it was all that and looked good. You wouldn't think drop shadows for icons could make such a huge difference, but they did! XP was worth upgrading your PC for...heck it was worth buying a new PC for, and many of us did, just to be able to run it in its full glory. The start menu seemed more intuitive, with new programs being highlighted, themes

started popping up everywhere, and desktop design competitions were kicked off everywhere. From the bundled DirectX 8.1, all the way to DirectX 9.0c (the final DX version for XP), games took on new meanings of fun and visual effects for XP users. The search got better, drivers could be uninstalled and downgraded for once, and I even remember having uptime competitions with Linux and BSD users – I may have always lost, but this was the first version of Windows that inspired enough confidence to even try and compete!

Windows Vista



Windows Vista – great to look at

Rating: Flop

We will not waste too much space on Vista – the less said the better. We remember seeing Aero and going “Wow!”, and then after the third time you [Alt] + [Tabbed], it was just another gimmick. To be honest (and serious) it was a pretty hefty upgrade, but it was also hardware hungry. DirectX 10 and all the bells and whistles were for the gamers, but Average Joe, PC user was not really interested in a whole new PC, especially after his five-year old PC was running perfectly fine on XP.

Windows 7

Rating: Good

Windows 7 seemed to be what Microsoft coders were aiming for when they built



Windows 7 – looks good and solid as a rock